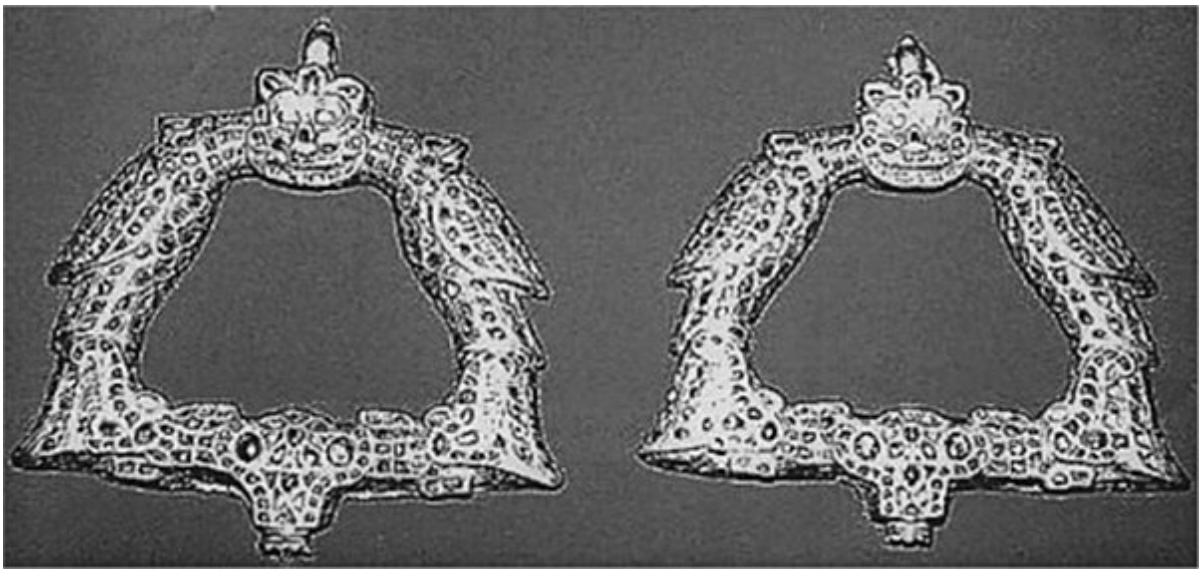


The pair of jewel-encrusted golden stirrups presented to the Meenakshi temple by the EICo administrator Rous Peter in the 1820s.

But there are other versions of the Rous Peter story. One is set down in the *Madurai District Gazetteer* of 1906, which tells us that Peter ‘lived in princely style, was of a most bountiful disposition (both the Meenakshi temple and the Alagarkovil possess valuable jewels which he gave them) and did great things in ridding the hills around Kaunivadsi, Periyakulam and Bodinaykkunur of the elephants which in those days infested them and the country below. The people nicknamed him “Peter Pandya”. He died in Madurai on 6 August 1828 and was buried in the heart of the town outside the then Protestant church.’

Government records show that Rous Peter did indeed secure a reduction in local taxes, as well as granting further reductions to no fewer than fifty-two villages. But then the story changes. The gift of stirrups was indeed a thank-offering – not for being rescued by a three-year-old goddess but ‘for an escape from an elephant he had wounded’. And now the story begins to grow darker: ‘The wildest stories about Rous Peter’s end are current in Madurai and it has been stated in print that he was charged with defalcation